DRAFT for discussion. These letters were drafted by a community member for the Princeton Board of Education to consider. They have not been adopted, approved or sent by the Board and do not represent its position. Facts as of October 29, 2026.

Letter 1: Board of Education to NJDEP

Send by November 9, 2026 through the online form at https://dep.nj.gov/boss/permit-comment-form/, or by mail.

[Date]

Nibras Mir
New Jersey Department of Environmental Protection
Bureau of Stationary Sources
401 E. State Street, 2nd Floor, PO Box 420, Mail Code 401-02
Trenton, NJ 08625-0420

Re: Draft Permit Comments for PN-DC1, PI 19525 PCP250001

Dear Nibras Mir:

The Princeton Board of Education submits these comments on the draft preconstruction permit for twelve diesel emergency generators at 4405 Route 1, South Brunswick. Our Littlebrook and Riverside Elementary Schools serve about 690 students, roughly 1.3 to 2 miles from the site, depending on where the generators sit on the 143-acre parcel. Closer still, within about a mile, are CIEL Senior Living, Spring Hills Princeton assisted living, Knowledge Beginnings child care, The Harmony School, and homes in South Brunswick, Kingston and Plainsboro. We ask the Department not to issue the permit until it has shown that children and residents are protected under every operating condition the permit allows.

1. The emission limits are calculated from testing hours only. The yearly limits equal exactly 12 engines × 28 hours of testing at the permitted hourly rates (for example, 75.28 lb/hr NOx × 336 hours = 12.65 tons). The permit lists each engine's yearly hours as 0 to 28. Yet Condition 18 also allows operation during power outages with no limit, for up to 30 days a year during construction, repair or maintenance at the facility, and during any PJM voltage reduction. The permit does not say whether these hours count toward the yearly limits, and the limits leave no room for them. At their permitted rates, all 12 engines together may emit about 900 lb of NOx per hour. About 55 hours of full operation would emit more than New Jersey's 25-ton-per-year major-source threshold.

2. The exhaust design keeps emissions low and close. The permit lists 33-foot stacks that discharge horizontally, 75 to 195 feet from the property line. Horizontal discharge removes the plume's upward momentum. A 341,000-square-foot building beside the stacks may also pull exhaust down to the ground.

3. All 12 engines may run at once, at any hour. The permit limits testing to one engine at a time between 8 a.m. and 8 p.m., with up to six at once only between noon and 4 p.m. These limits suggest that running more engines at once was a concern. Yet during an outage or grid emergency, all 12 may run together, including during school hours and on high-ozone days.

4. There is no emissions monitoring. Every emission limit lists "None" for monitoring. Only hour meters, logs and fuel delivery records are required, kept on site and provided only on request.

5. The health risk assessment is not public. The notice states that health risk is "negligible" under Technical Manual 1003. The public cannot evaluate that finding without the assessment itself.

6. Other agencies treat these risks more conservatively. The World Health Organization's cancer agency classifies diesel engine exhaust as carcinogenic to humans. In February 2026, Delaware's DNREC denied a proposed data center near Delaware City over its diesel generators, evaluating them at 500 hours a year, the worst-case default in EPA guidance. Washington's Department of Ecology prepared a health impact assessment for a data center in Quincy, which found data centers responsible for 30 to 75% of cancer risk from major air sources there.

We request that the Department:

1. Release the health risk assessment, modeling protocol, model files and plot plan, disclose where the generators sit on the parcel, and extend the comment period so the public can review them.
2. Report modeled concentrations at Littlebrook and Riverside Elementary Schools, and at the nearest homes, CIEL Senior Living, Spring Hills Princeton, Knowledge Beginnings and The Harmony School. Include diesel particulate matter, 1-hour NO_2, formaldehyde and other air toxics, with early-life exposure adjustments for children.
3. Model all 12 engines running together at full load during school hours, for at least the 30-day maintenance allowance, a multi-day outage, and the 500-hour-per-year worst case in EPA guidance. Prepare a health impact assessment like Washington State's.
4. State whether emergency and maintenance operation counts toward the yearly limits. If not, count it toward the limits and the facility's source classification, or justify in writing why not.
5. Prohibit operation during PJM voltage reductions unless the facility has actually lost grid power.
6. Require Tier 4 engines or diesel particulate filters, taller vertical stacks, and fence-line monitoring with public reporting.
7. Require the operator to report every hour of generator operation, with its cause, to the Department and the public within 30 days.
8. Prohibit testing during school hours on school days.

Thank you for your consideration. Please send notice of the final decision and the Response to Comments to [contact name, address and email].

Sincerely,

[Name]
President, Princeton Board of Education

cc: Sen. Andrew Zwicker; Asm. Roy Freiman; Asm. Mitchelle Drulis; Mayor Mark Freda and Princeton Council; [Superintendent]